

Best Buy Gold award. Xerox's M15i is an equally good performer and if you can overlook the software bundled with Samsung SCX-5215, you will end up saving a hefty Rs 7,000.

A3 heavy-duty MFDs

Four different machines from four different manufacturers were slotted in the A3 form factor. These are more rugged than the A4 machines, and offer heavy-duty capabilities. Since these machines are large, you will have to make some space in your office. They look like the old copier machines—huge and heavy. Toshiba was monstrous, and Ricoh and Sharp were not much smaller. Canon's iR1600 managed to save on space. Toshiba e-studio 160 also follows a modularity approach: the base unit is huge and comes with just the copier. The scanner and printer unit are added on demand and cost over a lakh, which incidentally was the price limit for all tested MFDs. Hence, we couldn't test them.

Printing

All these machines use laser-printing technology and are rated at different speeds. The Canon MFD is rated at 16 PPM, but managed 13 PPM. The model from Sharp was a disappointment—it's rated at 12 PPM on a USB 1.1 interface, but just about managed a pathetic 5 PPM, leaving no room for doubt that its printing engine is much inferior to that of Canon's. Ricoh's Aficio 2015 was able to print at 14 PPM—undeniably speedier than both, Sharp and Canon. All these machines are designed to offer a lowest cost-per-page—between 35 and 45 paise. We could not test the performance on the Toshiba MFD, but from the copying speed it does not look like a couch potato either.

Scanning

Sharp's AR-M160 has a decent scanning unit that's the best in this category. The accompanying software also adds to the practicality of the unit. Akin to the other MFDs manufactured by Canon, the iR1600 lacks the 'Scan to PC' feature. One interesting thing to note is that the Aficio 2015 from Ricoh offers only network-scanning and supports 256 shades of grey—no colour scanning. The same applies to Toshiba's e-studio 160: this clearly indicates their lineage—copier machines. All said and done, in terms of scanning performance, Sharp's AR-M160 stands tall.

Copying

Sharp's AR-M160 is a notch above Canon's iR1600, when it comes to usable features. Features such as enlarging or reducing, zooming, auto-exposure, etc., are present on both MFDs. However, copy-auditing, offset-stacking, etc., are a few features that Sharp offers, which add value to the bundle. The copy-auditing feature allows administrators to track usage on a per-user basis—specific people get accounts and need to enter a password before making copies. Similarly, offset-stacking stacks different jobs separately so that they don't get mixed. Other advance features such as copying 4 pages to one page, rotation, margin shifting, etc., can be enabled by optional accessories. These features are also the hallmark of Ricoh's Aficio 2150 and Toshiba's e-studio 160. Canon offers an optional stapling unit to staple multi-page documents



Why I use an MFD

Progress Publishers, Delhi-based publishers of school textbooks, have been using laser-based MFDs for over five years. For the last two years, **Anant Gupta**, proprietor, Progress Publishers, has been using the HP LaserJet 3300. It is shared by four or five users, and prints approximately 6,000 pages a month.

Gupta decided to buy an MFD for his office to get the benefits of a photocopier, without actually paying for one. He feels that the scanner in an MFD is not critical enough. He says, "The cost per

page is between 75 paise and Re 1 per copy, but I save a lot of space that an extra scanner would take. The print quality is satisfactory. It has all the basic features that all the products in its class have, such as printing modes—economy, 600 dpi, 1,200 dpi, memory, etc."

However MFDs do have their set of disadvantages. Says Gupta: "For originals with Photos and Text the result is barely satisfactory. Multiple trays aren't available, and the existing one can hold only 250 pages."



Caution

- ❗ Don't get carried away by pages per minute (ppm) claims. They vary depending on the coverage area of a page
- ❗ Humidity affects the working of a Laser MFD, so make sure you have a cool dry place for it in your office

automatically, thus helping you avoid a mix-up. This happens to be more effective than offset-stacking.

Sharp has six buttons that can be assigned to launch specific applications. For example, if you are OCRing a document, just press the button that's assigned to the OCR software. The scanned image opens in the application directly, thus speeding up the process. Sharp's AR-M160 was the only unit to bundle a colour scanner in this category.

Faxing

Faxing units on all these machines are optional, hence you will need to pay extra money to buy them.

Verdict for A3 heavy-duty MFDs

Nothing beats the Sharp AR-M160! The features it offers and its reasonable price tag, wins it our Best Buy Gold Award for this category. Its slow printing speeds might be a deterrent, and



A3 Heavy-duty MFDs



Sharp AR-M160

Loads of useful features and plenty of expansion options make the Sharp a good long-term bet

you might want to look for a USB 2.0 expansion card. Ricoh's Aficio 2015 was equally impressive, but lost valuable points in the scanning department. If printing and copying forms the bulk of your needs, and you can overlook the lack of colour scanning, the Aficio 2015 is a good choice. That also qualifies it for our Best Buy Silver Award.

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